

Breaking Into AI-Creative Work: Diagnosis and 90-Day Entry Strategy

Prepared: 2026-08-17 **Subject:** 23, NYC. Finance degree (Michigan State). KeyBank commercial banking analyst → Ad Sales Revenue & Expense Operations, DIRECTV Advertising (since March 2026). Shipped AI-creative portfolio, zero professional creative credits, single-digit applications, zero responses.

Supporting research: `research/phase-1.md` ... `research/phase-5.md`

Method limitation, stated up front. This research ran in an environment whose network policy blocked all direct page fetches (WebFetch → EGRESS_BLOCKED on every domain; curl → 403 at the proxy). Every finding below came through web search — indexed titles, URLs, and snippet content. I could not open LinkedIn postings to read applicant counts, could not read Discord threads, and could not verify individual "I joined X" posts. Claims that would normally require opening a page are marked **THIN**. The load-bearing findings (Upwork spending data, holdco layoff figures, the Victor Moreno and Liu Ziyu cases, Higgsfield Earn mechanics) are all multi-source and I'd stand behind them. The community-channel findings are not, and I say so where it matters.

Executive Summary

You are not getting silence because you lack talent. You are getting silence because **eight applications is not an experiment** — for your profile the arithmetic says zero responses is the ~92% likely outcome even if nothing were wrong. Nothing has been measured.

That's the comfortable half. The uncomfortable half: **scaling that channel is also wrong**. You'd need ~70 applications for a coin-flip at one reply, into postings that mostly demand 2–4 years, at employers cutting headcount — WPP is cutting hundreds more through 2026, Omnicom 4,000 post-IPG, and 91% of senior US agency leaders expect AI to shrink their staff. The holdco junior rung is closing while you knock on it.

Your portfolio is **below bar, but by less than it feels**. The gap isn't quality — your 4-character face-identity system with a 46-asset reference library is precisely the "repeatable workflow" evidence hiring managers say is missing from most portfolios. The gap is **shape and venue**: zero pieces that play start to finish, zero real-brand anchors, and it all lives on **GitHub Pages**, which reads as *engineer*, not *artist*. That miscategorization is already costing you — the one flagship application you made was to WPP Hex, a creative *technologist* program, the exact lane you'd ruled out.

The one clean junior hire I could trace: **Victor Moreno**, hired as an AI Artist at UNCUT off a **Nike spec ad with ~2,000 views in week one**, with **ComfyUI named as the deciding factor**. Not viral. Not an audience. One finished spec piece for a real brand, on a video platform.

Ninety days will not produce a full-time creative job — that's a 6–18 month arc and pretending otherwise costs you months. Ninety days can produce **first paid work, a portfolio at bar, and live conversations with people who hire**. Keep the DIRECTV job: it funds the runway, and knowing how ad revenue actually works is the rarest thing you own.

1. Diagnosis (ranked)

1. Sample size — the zero is uninformative. (~95% certain; it's arithmetic.) At a realistic 1% per-application response rate for a career-changer with no creative credits, 8 applications yield 0.08 expected responses. $P(\text{zero}) \approx 92\%$. You'd need ~69 applications for even odds of one reply, ~300 to be confident. *This explains the past and nothing about the future.*

2. Wrong channel. (~80% — and this is the actionable cause.) Every named success in the evidence was discovered through published finished work, never an application. The market's own hiring managers describe the mechanism explicitly. Applications are ~1/242. Referrals are 30–50% of US hires from 7% of applicants, with a 4x offer multiplier.

3. Portfolio format and venue below bar. (~75%.) Zero finished start-to-finish pieces. Zero real-brand anchors. Hosted on GitHub Pages as written case studies, in a market that hires off finished video on video platforms.

4. Resume/ATS mismatch. (~65%, but only where ATS exists.) 90%+ of employers screen by ATS. *KeyBank analyst* → *Ad Sales Revenue Ops* has no keyword surface for a creative req. Note the asymmetry: this bites hardest exactly where you were applying (WPP) and barely at all at the small shops where a founder reads the inbox.

5. Wrong role targets. (~55%.) Hex is 16 seats per cycle, globally, for the technologist lane you de-scoped. Most posted roles want 2–4 years. Holdcos are in net contraction.

The single cause the evidence most supports: the literal cause is **sample size**; the cause that will keep it zero is **channel**. You built an engineering-shaped artifact and pushed it through the lowest-yield channel in the market, at a volume too small to learn from.

2. Portfolio Verdict

Below the hiring bar. Roughly one finished piece away from being at it.

The derived bar (from real hires + real postings)

DIMENSION	BAR	YOU	
Pieces that play start-to-finish	1–3	0	✗
Real, recognizable brand anchor	≥1 (spec is fine)	0 — self-created brand	✗
Finishing: edit, sound design, grade	Table stakes	CapCut only	✗
Tool breadth	Multi-generator + real NLE/comp	Higgsfield + CapCut	✗
Venue	Video platform	GitHub Pages	✗
Social reach	Not required	Zero	✓
Repeatable-workflow evidence	Rare, valued	4 locked characters, 46-asset system	✓✓ above bar
Commercial literacy	Very rare	Ad-sales revenue/expense ops + finance	✓✓✓ unexploited

Answering your specific questions

- **Is a self-created brand read as weaker than any external brand, even unpaid? Yes.** Victor Moreno's hire object was a *Nike* spec ad. Inventing the brand removes the only thing a viewer can calibrate against — you control the brief, the tone, and the rules, so you cannot fail. A spec ad for a brand everyone knows is a test you can fail in public. That's why it counts.
- **Is Higgsfield-only a filter-out signal? Not by name** — Higgsfield appears in genuine job postings (e.g. a \$1,000 fixed-price Upwork role listing "Sora / ComfyUI / Higgsfield / OpenArt," 2026-02-19). But **Higgsfield-only is**. Postings enumerate 4–6 tools. And Higgsfield is an agentic layer that runs the pipeline for you; ComfyUI is evidence you understand the pipeline. Employers are buying the second thing.
- **Is the absence of a reel itself the problem? Largely yes — but don't make a reel.** A montage from someone with no professional credits is weak. Both traceable cases were *one complete piece*.
- **Is zero social reach the problem? No.** This is the comfortable explanation and the evidence rejects it. Victor Moreno was hired at ~2K views. Reach is a distribution mechanism, not a credential.

The two upgrades that most change your odds

Upgrade 1 — Ship one 45–60 second spec ad for a real brand: fully finished, graded, sound-designed, on YouTube and Instagram. Pick a brand adjacent to what you already have (streetwear/footwear/beverage — you have a locked visual language and 4 consistent characters, so reuse the system rather than starting over). Cut the case study to three lines under the video. The video is the artifact; the writing is a footnote.

Upgrade 2 — Move your portfolio off GitHub Pages. Get a real domain and a video-first landing page, or make a YouTube/Instagram profile the front door. Keep the GitHub site as a "process" link for anyone who asks. Right now your URL is telling creative hiring managers you're an engineer, and you have been believing it too.

(Third, sequenced behind these: start ComfyUI at week 4. It was the stated deciding factor in the one junior hire I could trace.)

3. Channel Allocation (~10 hrs/week)

CHANNEL	HRS/WK	EVIDENCED RESPONSE RATE	WHY
Making work (spec pieces + client delivery)	5.0	—	Every other channel is downstream of having the artifact
Freelance transaction (Upwork proposals, scoping, calls)	2.0	AI video +329% YoY on Upwork — fastest-growing category; 89% of first-time clients complete a contract. <i>Per-proposal rate: THIN</i>	Best hard evidence in the report
Direct outreach (named humans, artifact-led)	1.0	Cold email 3.43% aggregate (12M+ sends, Q1 2026); ~5% well-personalized. DM benchmarks of 15–35% are B2B sales data — discount to ~5–10%	~10x application yield
Posting/distribution	1.0	Not a lottery ticket — makes you findable when someone looks you up	Victor Moreno: 2K views sufficed
ComfyUI (from week 4)	0.75	—	The one traceable deciding credential
Applications	0.25	~0.5–1%	Near-zero. Do not scale

Additional channel, near-zero time cost, highest single-shot full-time probability: the internal move at DIRECTV.

DIRECTV Advertising is publicly standing up AI creative capability — AI-generated screensaver ads via Glance on Gemini devices starting early 2026, pause ads with new creative capabilities, execs on record about generative AI making TV-quality creative cheaper. You are already inside. Zero applicant competition. Fold this into your outreach hour.

Cut entirely: passive Discord lurking. I found no evidence gig flow transacts there. What survives is specific: the Curious Refuge **jobs board**, its **studio partnerships** (including a formal Promise relationship), its **NYC in-person meetups**, and Higgsfield's **CPP direct line to the creator team**.

4. The 90-Day Sequence

Weeks 1–2 — Ship the spec piece

- **Day 1:** Pick the brand. Real, recognizable, adjacent to your existing visual language. Write a one-line brief you could hand a client.
- **Day 1:** Register a domain. Video-first page. GitHub Pages demoted to a "process" link.
- **Days 2–10:** Produce the 45–60s spot. Storyboard → generate → **edit** → **grade** → **sound design**. The last three are where the bar is; budget half your time there. If CapCut can't grade it, learn DaVinci Resolve's free tier — it's a weekend, not a semester.
- **Day 3 (parallel, 30 min):** Register for **Higgsfield Earn**. Submit to an open campaign that week. 90% approval rate, weekly ~\$100k pool, open to creators of any size. This is your fastest route to a *paid brand credit*, not to income.
- **Days 11–14:** Publish to YouTube + Instagram. Rewrite your LinkedIn headline to lead with the work, not the ops title.

Weeks 3–4 — Turn it on

- Post the piece and 2–3 process cuts (behind-the-scenes of the character system — this is your differentiated content, almost nobody else can show it).
- **Upwork live.** Position as *"performance creative for advertisers — AI video by someone who reads the campaign P&L."* Not "AI video guy." 5–8 proposals/week, targeting the **\$150–\$1,200/deliverable** band. Refuse the \$20 tier.
- **First 10 outreach messages** (template below). Targets: Collier Simon, Genre.ai, Wonder Studios, Utopai, plus 6 NYC independents standing up AI video units.
- **Week 4:** ComfyUI starts. One hour a week, background thread.
- **The DIRECTV conversation.** Find whoever owns creative/ad products. Not "can I have a job" — *"I've been making AI video on the side, here's a spot I cut. I hear we're doing more with generative creative. Can I help with anything?"* You are the cheapest resource they will ever be offered.

Weeks 5–8 — Volume and conversion

- **Second spec piece.** Different brand, different register (if piece 1 was atmospheric, make this one funny — *"if you make funny spec commercials, they will hire you"*). Use ComfyUI for at least one component so you can say you did.
- Upwork: 8–10 proposals/week. Take the first gig even if underpriced — the first review is worth more than the fee.
- Outreach: 10/week, cumulative 50+. Always artifact-first.
- Attend one **Curious Refuge NYC meetup**. In-person converts to referral; referral is the 4x multiplier.
- Keep submitting to Higgsfield Earn campaigns — they're real briefs from real brands, handed to you free.

Weeks 9–12 — Compound

- **Third piece**, or first real client work becomes the portfolio piece (client work outranks spec, always).

- Convert one client to a small retainer conversation. **\$1,500–\$8,000/mo** is the tier where this replaces income; a single \$2,000/mo retainer plus the day job is a credible bridge.
- Apply — selectively, ~3 total — to genuinely junior postings: freelance-to-hire listings (an "AI Artist — freelance to permanent" role in NYC is a real, posted structure), Curious Refuge jobs board, independents. Not holdcos.
- Reassess the DIRECTV internal path with 90 days of evidence behind you.

Outreach template (artifact-first; personalization roughly doubles reply rate)

Subject: spec spot for [Brand] — 52 seconds

[Name] — I made this on spec for [Brand]: [link]

Consistent character identity across the whole spot using a locked reference system I built (46 assets, 4 characters, swappable wardrobe). Graded and sound-designed. Solo, [X] days.

Day job is ad sales revenue ops at DIRECTV Advertising, so I know what a campaign costs and why creative variants under-deliver — unusual combination for someone making the assets.

Saw [specific thing they shipped]. If you ever need overflow on AI video, I'd like to be on that list.

— [name]

Rules: lead with the link; never attach a resume; one specific reference to their actual work; ask for the overflow list, not a job. Generic AI-written outreach actively damages trust in 2026 — send 10 real ones over 100 templated ones.

Target list

Tier 1 — independents & small AI-native (founder reads the inbox): Collier Simon · Genre.ai · Wonder Studios · Utopai Studios · Agency Within · NYC independent shops standing up AI video units **Tier 2 — AI-native studios (senior-weighted; play the long game):** Promise · Asteria · Secret Level · Toonstar · Invisible Universe · Pigeon Shrine · TCL Studios · Netflix INKubator **Tier 3 — production-at-scale:** Brandtech+ / OLIVER (mid-to-senior, hub in South Africa — low odds, know it going in) **Removed:** WPP, Omnicom/IPG, Publicis. Net contraction. Hex is a once-a-year lottery ticket, correctly priced at zero.

5. Leading Indicators and the Pivot Rule

By Day 30 you should see: - One finished spec piece live on a video platform ✓ (fully in your control — if this is missing, nothing else in this report matters) - At least one Higgsfield Earn payout approved - 1–3 Upwork proposal replies out of ~20 - 1–2 replies from ~20 outreach messages - Portfolio off GitHub Pages - One conversation started internally at DIRECTV

By Day 60: - Two finished pieces - **First paid client work delivered** (any amount) - 3–5 live conversations with people who could hire or refer - One repeat client or a second gig from the same source - ComfyUI: one piece with a ComfyUI component in it

Pivot rules: - **No spec piece live by Day 30** → the problem is execution capacity, not the market. Cut scope to 30 seconds and ship. Everything downstream is blocked on this. - **Piece live, zero outreach replies from 40+ messages by Day 45** → the work is below bar. Get brutal external critique (post it for feedback in the Higgsfield/CR communities, ask specifically about finishing quality) before sending message 41. - **Replies but no paid work by Day 60** → pricing or positioning. Drop your rate once, deliberately, to buy the first review, then raise it. - **Paid work but nothing above \$300/deliverable by Day 90** → you're in the commodity tier. Stop competing on generation; rebuild the pitch entirely around the advertiser-economics wedge. - **Day 90, none of the above** → the honest read is that 10 hrs/week isn't enough while the day job drains you. The answer is *more concentrated hours* (a two-week PTO sprint), not quitting. Nothing in this evidence supports leaving DIRECTV inside 90 days.

6. Honest Odds

OUTCOME (BY DAY 90)	PROBABILITY	BASE RATE BEHIND IT
(a) Full-time creative role	5–8%	External FT with zero creative credits, into reqs demanding 2–4 yrs, in a market cutting headcount. Typical arc is 6–18 months. The DIRECTV internal move is the best single shot and adds maybe 3–5 points — but would likely land creative- <i>adjacent</i> , not pure creative
(b) First paid AI-creative work	~80%	Higgsfield Earn alone: 90% approval, weekly \$100k pool, open to any size — likely inside 2–5 weeks. Requires only that you submit
(b') First paid work from a real external client (stricter)	50–60%	Upwork AI video +329% YoY, but requires the portfolio piece to exist plus ~40 proposals
(c) Neither	15–20%	Concentrated almost entirely in the scenario where the spec piece never ships

Read the split honestly. (a) is low and no amount of effort inside 90 days moves it much — that's the market, not you. (b) is high and mostly under your control. The dominant risk in (c) isn't the market rejecting you; it's a draining day job eating the 10 hours. Your 3-month deadline is achievable if you define it as *credible path in motion* — which is what you actually said you needed. Redefined as *signed full-time offer*, it is not, and someone should tell you that now rather than on day 89.

Appendix — Kill List

STRATEGY CONSIDERED	WHY REJECTED
Scale applications to 100+	~1/242 yield, into reqs wanting 2–4 yrs, at employers cutting headcount. Buys 1–2 responses for the whole quarter
Target WPP / Omnicom / Publicis	Net contraction: WPP hundreds more cuts through 2026, Omnicom 4,000 post-IPG, 91% of agency leaders expect AI headcount reduction
Re-apply to WPP Hex / chase apprenticeships	16 seats per cycle globally; it's the creative <i>technologist</i> lane you explicitly de-scoped
Build a social following first	Zero reach isn't the problem — Victor Moreno was hired at ~2K views. Audience-building is a 2-year arc (Zack London), not a 90-day plan
Aim for a viral hit	Survivorship bias. Liu Ziyu and Zack London surfaced in research <i>because</i> they're rare. Target findability, not virality
Make a montage reel	A reel from someone with no professional credits is weak. Both traceable cases were one complete piece
Learn ComfyUI first, ship later	Would consume the 90 days with nothing published. Resequenced to week 4 as a background thread
Enter AI film festivals as a hiring channel	Runway's \$50k Grand Prix winner reportedly had no interest in converting it to a job. Prizes and legitimacy, not a funnel
Live in Discord communities	No evidence gig flow transacts there. Replaced by CR jobs board + NYC meetups + Higgsfield CPP
Compete on price on Upwork	Floor is \$20/video and ComfyUI FT roles list at \$15–21/hr. Race to zero
Add more written case studies	You already over-index here. The market hires on finished moving images
Quit DIRECTV to focus full-time	It funds the runway, is your only warm industry network, and is the differentiator that gets you out of the commodity tier
Pursue creative technologist / pipeline roles	Out of scope by your own targeting — though note your GitHub Pages portfolio has been quietly pushing you there

Sources

Market structure & hiring mechanics Ad Age — WPP cuts through 2026 · FT/MarketScreener — Omnicom 4,000 cuts · AI CERTs — agency layoffs, 91% stat · eMarketer — Omnicom talent-to-AI shift · Interview Guys — 242 applications/opening · CNBC — LinkedIn AI hiring flood · Authentic Jobs — hiring designers in the age of AI · ERIN — referral statistics 2026

Who hires WPP — Creative Tech Apprenticeship · ContentGrip — inside WPP Hex · Variety VIP — AI entertainment studios · Deadline — Promise senior hires · Variety — Asteria/ZeroSpace · Variety — Christina Lee Storm to Secret Level · IT News Africa — Brandtech+ 100 roles · Digiday — Unilever Beauty AI Studio · Curious Refuge — Creative AI Jobs Board

The hiring bar / named cases Curious Refuge — How To Get Hired As An AI Artist (Victor Moreno) · SCMP — Liu Ziyu, \$440 AI short, Hollywood job offer · THR — Zack London / Gossip Goblin · IndieWire — Gossip Goblin theatrical release · THR — Robert Gaudette, Runway AIFF Grand Prix · The Media Brain — PJ Accetturo interview · Creative Boom — AI turning the ad industry on its head · Hire Digital — hiring a generative AI designer

Freelance & creator economics Upwork — In-Demand Skills 2026 (investor release) · CNBC — Upwork fastest-growing skills · Playcut — AI video rates 2026 · Higgsfield Earn · Higgsfield Creator Partnership Program · Digiko — reading the Earn split · Startup Fortune — Higgsfield training-license terms · Smartlead — cold outreach benchmarks 2026 · Phantom — cold outreach statistics 2026

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